

Democracy In Software

For those of you new to the concept, open source software is that which is open to modification by the user, as opposed to closed source, where you only get an executable file and cannot modify it in any way. What model will prevail in this century is the subject of much analysis, and opinions abound.

So why would you want to modify the code of a program? It could be for testing one's programming skills, for enhancing the functionality of the software, just for the sheer fun of it, or — which is most often the case — to get involved in the community effort. You see, open source programs are usually ongoing projects; unlike a company coming out with a finished product, in the open source world, people collaborate and share. They listen to user requests. They listen to comments and reviews. In short, the entire computing experience is like one group effort.

In this book, we present the best and most popular open source programs available across various categories. The first chapter walks you through the basics of what the open source movement is all about. Then come chapters each devoted to a specific software segment — audio, video, and graphics manipulation programs, system and office tools, Internet-related software, security-related programs, and educational software. At the end, as is customary, we throw in a chapter on Internet resources — places on the Web to visit after having gone through the book.

Remember that the code of every program mentioned in this book is freely available for download. You can modify them and redistribute the software — subject to terms you'll learn about in the first chapter. For that, of course, you'll need some programming skills: if you already do, we encourage you to play around with the software and get back to us about it! And if you don't have programming experience, do look forward to future books in this series that could focus on programming.

Oh, did we forget to mention that all the software mentioned here are free of cost?

Enjoy!